

Adherence to the WCRF/AICR guidelines for cancer prevention is associated with lower mortality among older female cancer survivors

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Background The 2007 World Cancer Research Fund/American Institute for Cancer Research (WCRF/AICR) guidelines encourage cancer survivors to follow its cancer prevention recommendations. We evaluated whether adherence to the WCRF/AICR guidelines for cancer prevention was associated with lower mortality among older female cancer survivors. **Methods** From 2004–2009, 2,017 participants in the Iowa Women’s Health Study who had a confirmed cancer diagnosis (1986–2002) and completed the 2004 follow-up questionnaire were followed. Adherence scores for the WCRF/AICR guidelines for body weight, physical activity, and diet were computed assigning one, 0.5 or 0 points to each of eight recommendations depending on the degree of adherence. All-cause (n=461), cancer-specific (n=184), and cardiovascular disease (CVD)-specific mortality (n=145) were compared by the total adherence score and by adherence scores for each of the three components of the recommendations. **Results** Women with the highest (6–8) vs. lowest (0–4) adherence score had lower all-cause mortality (HR=0.67, 95%CI=0.50–0.94). Meeting the physical activity recommendation was associated with lower all-cause (ptrend<0.0001), cancer-specific (ptrend=0.04), and CVD-specific mortality (ptrend=0.03). Adherence to dietary recommendations was associated with lower all-cause mortality (ptrend<0.05), whereas adherence to the body weight recommendation was associated with higher all-cause mortality (ptrend=0.009). **Conclusions** Adherence to the WCRF/AICR guidelines was associated with lower all-cause mortality among older female cancer survivors. Adherence to the physical activity recommendation had the strongest association with lower all-cause and disease-specific mortality. **Impact** Older cancer survivors may decrease their risk of death by leading a healthy lifestyle after a cancer diagnosis.